



BHASKAR PAUL



RAVI'S SAHANI

THE NGMA IN  
MUMBAI (TOP)  
AND IN DELHI

artist M.S. Murthy, protesting the callous treatment of artists. "We didn't even get invitations. If we don't count and are so dispensable, then why come to our city at all," he reasons. It's not just Murthy. Nationally acclaimed artists seem to have been ignored: Yusuf Arakkal received the invitation only after the event; S.G. Vasudev just a day before it. "I don't expect any better from them," says Arakkal.

The result? A morose art community that feels that most of the NGMA's efforts have come too little and too late. A quick comparison on the visitors sets the record straight. Delhi's NGMA gets 30,000 annual visitors, Mumbai gets 28,000 visitors (at Rs 10 per head) and school visits (free trips) add up to an additional 10,000. Compare this with the Museum of Modern Art (\$30) in New York, with 2.5 million annual visitors; the Louvre (€12.5) in Paris, with 2.5 million; and the Tate Modern (£20) in London, with about four million annual visitors.

Oblivious to the resentment, NGMA Director Rajeev Lochan says it's time to celebrate. "We now have a world

## Around the World

- China has 83 national level museums. There will be 100 additional museums by 2010.
- UAE pledged \$32 billion in 2008 to develop museums and art programmes.
- Hong Kong launched a cultural plan in 2008 costing \$2.8 billion, an unprecedented investment in art for the city.
- Singapore, Thailand and the Philippines have invested in a dozen museums each.

class museum and it is reason enough for every art lover to celebrate," he argues. Lochan makes a point when he says that art and the community should put their egos aside. But artists solely blame the NGMA. "There is nothing wrong with the NGMA, it is after all a national institution. The problem is that it is run by incompetent people,"

explains Arakkal. Murthy, on the other hand, is distraught that neither the director nor Minister of Culture Ambika Soni chose to stand up when Ramchandra Gowda, minister for education, said, "Pseudo-intellectuals use modern art conveniently to insult Indian heritage."

Artists are disgruntled that the NGMA has no comprehensive policy for the development of modern art in the country. The director is a government appointee and the NGMA is at the mercy of ministers. In 2001, for instance, the then cultural minister Maneka Gandhi had proposed to sell a bulk of the NGMA's collection to raise money, despite opposition from the art world. The decision was never implemented, but it did highlight the fanciful working of ministers. One cannot help asking the obvious question: Besides the director, where are the artists, curators, museum experts and academics? Though the so-called permanent collections, both at the C.J. Hall in Mumbai as well as the present exhibition at Bangalore's NGMA, contain some of the best works of art in the country, the display, labelling, and information leave a lot to be desired, especially if one were to compare it with permanent collections in the world. Complete autonomy, albeit as a government-funded institution, may help but there is no such proposal. Another concern is that neither the Mumbai nor the Bangalore centre is to be decentralised. The fear that both centres will end up as extensions of the Delhi NGMA looms large. "Presently, the NGMA is completely irrelevant to my life and work," says Sharan Apparao of Apparao Galleries who was on the advisory panel of the gallery.

Will privatisation help? "Galleries are privately owned. The NGMA is not a gallery, it's a museum," reasons Lochan, defending the institution that houses 17,813 works of 1,742 artists dating back to 1857. Artist Akbar Padamsee puts it best: "Yes, the NGMA has alienated artists, but private galleries are for the rich. This is for the people. We as artists must also walk half the distance. Only then will such institutions work." Is anyone listening? ■